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STANDING APART IN A SEA OF OPTIONS


Rev. Dr. Lourdu Prasad Joseph, Rector



With hundreds of colleges dotting Karnataka's academic map, the real challenge for students today isn't access, it's choosing wisely. Amid the noise of rankings, infrastructure claims and placement numbers, very few institutions manage to stand out for the right reasons. St. Philomena's College is one of them.

Founded in 1946, the college has stayed committed to its purpose while evolving with time. At a stage when many colleges lean heavily on appearances or affiliations, St. Philomena's has focused instead on strengthening its academic framework, investing in faculty development and nurturing an environment where students are not just trained but truly taught.

Autonomous and multidisciplinary, the college offers a wide spectrum of undergraduate, postgraduate and research programmes ranging from humanities and basic sciences to commerce, management and newly introduced AICTE-approved courses like MBA and MCA. But its real edge lies in timely curricula updates, rigorous internal assessments and a structured mentoring system that ensures students aren't lost in the crowd.

"We are proud of our rich legacy but we don't rest on it. Our focus is on building an institution that embraces change, values inclusivity and ensures that no student feels unseen. Our mentoring and academic support systems are designed to help every individual grow, both academically and personally, affirms Dr Ravi JD Saldanha, Principal, St. Philomena's College.

There's also a strong emphasis on student-centred learning including research projects at the UG level, paper presentations and labs practices. The institution's emphasis on outcome-based education and NEP-aligned reforms reflects a conscious effort to prepare students for the world beyond the college confines.

A CULTURE OF ACCOUNTABILITY AND DEPTH

One of the most striking aspects of the college is its disciplined academic environment. The Internal Quality Assurance Cell functions actively, ensuring that every department adheres to periodic syllabus revision, internal benchmarking and academic audits. Course content is updated in consultation with industry experts, alumni and subject specialists to keep up with both theoretical advancements and job market shifts.

The college follows a credit-based semester system and adopts a mix of evaluation modes, from assignments and tests to projects and presentations. Students are mentored not only in academics but in decision-making, career planning and soft skills, which helps them transition from classrooms to real-world contexts more confidently.

ENABLERS, NOT JUST INSTRUCTORS

What often gets overlooked in college evaluations is the role of faculty not just in delivering lectures but in shaping mindsets. Teachers here undergo regular orientation and training programmes, engage in research and are encouraged to innovate in pedagogy. Many are actively involved in publishing and presenting papers, which helps bring a research orientation into the classroom.

More importantly, there's an institutional culture of mentorship. With class advisors and individual counselling systems in place, students have access to faculty not just during lecture hours but for academic and personal guidance.

INFRASTRUCTURE THAT SUPPORTS LEARNING

The campus infrastructure is well-organised and built around academic needs. From fully-equipped science and computer labs to digital classrooms and department-specific libraries, the focus is clearly on functionality. The central library, e-resource centres and seminar halls serve as learning extensions.

The college has also taken steps to integrate technology in both teaching and administration. ICT-enabled learning, virtual labs, online assessments and blended learning options are being steadily scaled up that reflects a willingness to adapt without losing pedagogical intent.

GOING BEYOND THE CURRICULUM

Students here are encouraged to take part in research conclaves, cultural events, intercollegiate competitions, and extension activities. National Service Scheme (NSS) units, eco clubs and entrepreneurship cells provide platforms for real-world exposure and social engagement.

Internships, particularly in the MBA and MCA programmes, are built into the curriculum, not treated as optional add-ons. The institution also supports entrepreneurial aspirations through innovation cells and linkages with incubation centres. Students with ideas are given the space and support to explore them.

A MODEL OF CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

Over the decades, St. Philomena's has produced a wide and diverse alumni network ranging from civil servants and academics to entrepreneurs and professionals across industries. Many of them remain engaged with the college, contributing as guest speakers, mentors and advisors. Their ongoing involvement is not only a testament to the college's influence but also a valuable resource for current students seeking guidance and connections.

Perhaps what makes the institute stand out most is its balance of continuity and change. It has neither clung to legacy for comfort nor rushed to rebrand itself with every new trend. Instead, it has built an identity based on academic credibility, student focus and a culture of measured evolution.

In an era when higher education often feels transactional, they continue to invest in its core promise to educate, mentor and guide.

PU COLLEGE OFFERING BALANCED EDUCATION

Adding to its commitment to shaping young minds, St. Philomena's Pre-University College, registered under the Mysore Diocesan Educational Society (MDES), has opened admissions for the upcoming academic year. The institution stands out for its value-based education, holistic development approach and a wide array of academic combinations tailored to meet the evolving aspirations of today's students. The college offers combinations across science including PCMB, PCBH, PCMC and PCME, for commerce they have BASC and EGBA and arts students can opt for HEGP and HESP. It enables the students to align their studies with future goals.

The campus blends academics with co-curricular enrichment in an eco-friendly setting. From CET and NEET coaching to sports, NSS, Rovers and Rangers, students are encouraged to pursue their passions alongside studies. Facilities like a multimedia conference hall, indoor stadium, cafeteria and hostels enhance the campus experience. While counselling and career guidance sessions help students make confident decisions. English is the medium of instruction here, with optional languages including Kannada, Hindi, Tamil, Malayalam, Urdu and French, along with provisions for private study in Sanskrit, Telugu and Arabic.

Recognising academic achievement, the college also offers merit scholarships including free admission for those scoring above 98 percent in the State SSLC examination and fee concessions for those in the 95 percent to 97 percent bracket.

"We believe education is not just about textbooks but about building character, confidence and clarity of vision. Our goal is to nurture responsible citizens who are prepared to meet the challenges of tomorrow," says Sunil D'Souza, Principal of the PU College.

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A Legacy in Motion

St. Philomena's College was established on October 9, 1946, under the guidance of His Excellency Rene Feuga MEP, the then Bishop of Mysore. It was made possible through the support and generosity of His Highness Sri Jayachamarajendra Wodeyar, the Maharaja of the then princely state of Mysore. As the first private science college in the region, its foundation marked a significant step in expanding access to higher education in Mysuru.

Now in its 79th year, the college has grown steadily. Traditional programmes continue alongside newer, job-oriented courses. With 27 undergraduate departments and 13 postgraduate programmes, the institution has also become a recognised centre for research, offering PhD opportunities in four disciplines. These developments have brought in faculty with diverse academic backgrounds and widened the scope for students.

In 2023, two professional programmes, MBA and MCA, were introduced, both approved by AICTE, New Delhi. In 2024, an MSc in Food Science and Nutrition was added, supported by newly developed infrastructure. These additions reflect the college's efforts to meet changing academic and professional trends.

As we approach the college's centenary in 2046, the need for forward planning becomes increasingly relevant. Growing student numbers, changing academic priorities and infrastructural demands all call for a long-term vision.

The college follows the motto 'Caritas in Scientia' (Service through Knowledge). Alongside regular teaching, we are working to create an academic environment that encourages inquiry, collaboration and critical thinking.

Institutions like ours also carry a broader responsibility. Education today must respond not only to academic needs but also to the social realities of the country. A large section of our population still faces economic hardship. In this context, the education imparted here should translate into skills and understanding that can be used to support the wider community. As we continue this journey, the aim is to stay relevant, respond to new challenges, and ensure that the institution remains a meaningful space for learning and growth.

Rev. Dr Lourdu Prasad Joseph,
Rector,
St. Philomena's College

Guided by Tradition, Focused on Tomorrow



St. Philomena's is a living legacy of the foresight and dedication of visionary predecessors who laid a strong foundation. Over the years, they have played a key role in the institution's all-round development. We are fortunate to be part of a college blessed with many strengths including heritage buildings, inspiring former teachers, dedicated faculty, committed non-teaching staff, talented students and alumni who continue to make us proud.

While we value our rich past, we understand the importance of moving forward. The task of building on this legacy is both challenging and important. We are focused on shaping an institution that is open to change and responsive to the academic and social demands of the present and future.

We believe in inclusive education and the need to constantly evolve to meet new expectations. To move in this direction, we count on the support of all stakeholders including parents, guardians, staff and well-wishers.

Dr Ravi JD Saldanha, Principal, St. Philomena











It has been a matter of pride and privilege to serve this reputed institution for the past 25 years—first as a lecturer and then as Principal of the PU College. With the constant support of the management, staff, students, and parents, we navigated several challenges, especially during the pandemic. I am grateful for the trust placed in me and proud of our collective achievements. I look forward to continuing this journey with renewed energy towards the Centenary celebrations.

Sunil D'Souza, Principal
St. Philomena's Pre-University College, Mysore